9.3 Communitarianism

Communitarianism emerged as a political doctrine during the 1980s when Michael Sandel authored the book 'Liberalism and the Limits of Justice'. He criticised the libertarianism and its thinker John Rawls in that work. The other political scientists supporting communitarianism include Alisdair MacIntyre, Michael Walzer, Charles Taylor, Amitai Etzioni nd Will Kymlicka. Though the British Socialist Goodwyn Barmy coined the word "communitarian" in the 1840s, the doctrine of communitarianism emerged only towards the end of the 20th century



In short Balancing the Rights and Responsibilities of Individual with Rights and Responsibilities of Community.

Communitarianism rose as a revolt against the prevailing two ideologies of libertarianism and Marxism. It criticised the thinkers of libertarianism for their over emphasis on individuals. It rejected Marxism for being committed to class-based action and analysis. However, the opposition was directed against Libertarianism that had become the ruling philosophy of mankind especially in the western world.

Importance of Community

Communitarianism argues that man is not born in a vacuum. He is a social and cultural animal. Individuals are born in a community or culture and therefore inherit it. Their beliefs, behavior, skills, capacities, attitudes etc are predominantly influenced by the community. Every individual builds on these commonly available and acquired capacities to make a mark in his or her life time. Man is not an atomistic entity existing alone but is embedded in the community. The individual is not 'unencumbered self' (completely free) from society but 'situated self' (rooted and planted) in society

For example a child born in Tamil Nadu speaks Tamil language fluently and not Japanese where as a child born in Japan speaks Japanese fluently and not Tamil. A man living in a community where computer technology is already available in developed form may become a skilled person in software domain. On the contrary, a man living in a remote community that has not witnessed the growth of information technology will not have adequate software skills.

Concept of State

Communitarianism considers the State as a positive instrument that promotes the idea of the common good. The concept of common good is present in every community. The community develops a set of goals, practices and measures that collectively promote the fundamental welfare of all. The State should promote the realisation of the common good and act against the activities that promote individual good in contradiction with common good. It should protect and promote those cultural traditions of the community that symbolise and sustain

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